

The Lost Lantern Festival

The Floating Isles are islands adrift in a calm sky, in a realm where magic only ever helps: it grows, it heals, it changes one thing into another, and it lets you speak with animals and objects. It never harms. On the home island, the House of the Little Mages sits at the highest point, where young mages learn their first spells, and the city where the families live spreads below. Inside the school grounds lies the Great Garden, the green heart of the whole island. Here nobody loses; you find your way by being kind and full of ideas.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.

★ *Read aloud, or let an older child read. Pause at the questions and let everyone share their ideas. There are no wrong answers, only new ones to try.*

Before you begin

Tonight should be the best night of the year: the Festival of Lights, when every family on the Floating Isles sends a glowing sky lantern drifting up into the calm evening sky until the whole heavens shine. But from the high windows of the House of the Little Mages, you can see that something is wrong. The sky is empty and dark. Down below, Lantern Square sits grey and silent, and not a single light is rising.

You are young mages, and tonight the lights are yours to find. You shoulder your bags, share a quick and certain look, and set off down the winding path. "Let us bring the festival back," you say, and the dark square waits for you below.

★ *What is your mage name? Which magic feels most like you tonight: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice?*

Stop 1 The Dim Square

Lantern Square should be ringing with music and warm with a hundred small flames. Instead it is hushed and shadowed, and only one sky lantern remains, sitting forgotten on a cold stone with its little flame snuffed out.

The Mist Cat pads out of the evening fog, soft and grey, and settles beside the lantern. It looks from the cold wick to the sky above, where the faintest ribbon of light still hangs in the air, drifting up and away toward a distant bank of cloud.

★ *How will you wake the lantern's flame, and how might you discover where all the others have gone? Try something, and see what the night gives back.*

When the little flame catches and glows, the lantern lifts from the stone and rises gently along that ribbon of light, as if inviting you to follow. So you do, up and up toward the waiting clouds.

Stop 2 The Cloud Bank

At the very edge of the island, where the ground gives way to open sky, you come to a low bank of clouds, soft as wool and faintly warm. Look closely and you will see it: here and there a cloud glows quietly from within, as though it has swallowed a little sun. The missing lanterns are tucked away inside.

A Messenger Butterfly, bright as a coal, comes spiralling down to lend a wing.

★ *Which clouds are keeping a lantern, and how can you be sure? And once you know, how will you reach so high and gather them in? Try something, and see.*

One by one you coax the glowing lanterns out of their cloudy nests, until they bob and circle around you in a soft, happy swarm of light. Only the grandest lantern of all, the great one that crowns the whole festival, is still nowhere to be seen.

Stop 3 The High Ledge

You tip your heads back and find it at last. Far above the square, the biggest festival lantern has drifted up against a jutting rocky ledge and snagged there, glowing stubbornly out of reach. It is much too high to climb to, and in any case you would never want anyone to risk a fall. This one must come down softly and safely.

The evening breeze loops and curls around the ledge, patient and willing.

★ *How will you bring the great lantern down without anyone in danger? Could you grow something soft to catch it, or ask the breeze for the gentlest of nudges, or change a pebble into a kindly hook? Try something, and see.*

When the great lantern drifts down at last and settles into your waiting hands, the whole square seems to hold its breath. Every lantern is found now, but one question still glimmers unanswered: why did the lights leave at all?

Nimbo the Cloud-Whale Calf

High in the quiet clouds you find the answer curled up small: a young cloud-whale calf, shy and round, made of pale drifting cloud, with a soft warm glow shining deep inside it. Its name is Nimbo. It was Nimbo, you understand now, who gathered every lantern, one by one, into the sky.

Not out of mischief, and not to spoil a thing. Nimbo had been alone for a long time in the wide empty evening, and when the warm little lights began to rise, it loved them so dearly that it could not bear to let them drift on by.

There is no battle here, and there never was a villain.

★ *What do you say to Nimbo? How can you show it that it has not been forgotten, and that there is a place for it down at the festival too?*

When you offer Nimbo your friendship, it lets out a happy, rumbling sigh and opens its cloudy heart, and all the gathered light streams free. The sky lanterns rise as one, the evening blooms into warm and endless gold, and Nimbo, brightest of them all, drifts gently down to take its place among the families. The Festival of Lights has begun, and no one is alone in it.

You did this together. You were kind, and you were full of ideas, and on the Isles that is the only way anyone ever wins.

The Lost Lantern Festival: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which on the Isles means a few small jobs at once: narrator, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses.

Setting up

- You do not need a printed map for this one. Picture the journey from Lantern Square up to the clouds, or lay out three small spots to be the three stops.
- Each player chooses one magic: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice. Two different magics work best, because combining them is half the fun.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the things that come up (a paper lantern, a vine, a little hook) from household bits and bricks as you go. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Instead each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge in this story can be played with a single ordinary die, and richer dice sets simply make it feel grander.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to try the same idea again, or
- **Combine two magics** once per stop to pass the challenge with no roll at all (Light and Voice, say, or Grow and Change, working as one).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. So nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. The lesson underneath the whole game is that you get further together.

The surprise

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a surprise and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for surprises; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Surprise
1	A Messenger Butterfly drifts past and gives you one free hint.

2	You catch a spark of warm light: take back one energy star.
3	A kind, steady breeze: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Mist Cat appears and purrs. All is well; carry on.
5	A friendly lantern lights your way: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A little festival song drifts by and everyone hums along for one happy turn.

How it ends

The festival is not won by catching anyone or putting anything right by force. The one who gathered the lanterns is Nimbo, a young cloud-whale who was lonely and loved the lights too much to let them go. The adventure is won when the children offer Nimbo their friendship and a place at the festival. Let that land gently; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for how to play the ending, and for the solutions to the three stops.

The Lost Lantern Festival: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Dim Square (Easy)

The challenge. The last sky lantern has gone cold and dark, and the players need to relight it and work out where the other lanterns have drifted off to.

Intended solutions. Any of the magics can help:

- **Light** wakes the little flame at once, and lights up the faint trail leading to the clouds.
- **Change** turns a cold ember or a pebble into a warm, glowing one.
- **Voice:** ask the lantern itself, or the Mist Cat, where the others went; both are happy to point up toward the cloud bank.

Fallback. If a roll misses, the Mist Cat nudges the lantern and looks pointedly up at the trail of light, then the players spend an energy star or combine two magics to finish. Nobody waits in the dark for long.

Stop 2: The Cloud Bank (Normal)

The challenge. Several lanterns are hidden inside a bank of soft clouds. The players must work out which clouds hold a lantern, and how to reach them.

Intended solution. The clue is that a hidden lantern makes its cloud glow softly and feel warm, while the empty clouds stay cool and grey. This is an **observation** moment: pick out the warm, glowing clouds. Then reach them with **Grow** (a vine ladder or a tall reed), with **Voice** (ask the Messenger Butterfly or the breeze to carry them down), or with a combined magic.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have the Messenger Butterfly hover beside one glowing cloud to show them what "warm and glowing" looks like, then let them find the rest. Getting there with a nudge still counts as a full success, and tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The High Ledge (Normal)

The challenge. The biggest festival lantern has caught on a high rocky ledge, out of reach. The players must bring it down gently, with no one climbing into any danger.

Intended solutions. This is a kindness-and-care puzzle, not a daring climb:

- **Grow** a thick cushion of leaves or a soft vine below to catch the lantern.
- **Voice:** ask the evening breeze for the gentlest nudge to float it free.
- **Change** a pebble into a soft hook on a long grown stem to lift it down. Any plan that brings it down safely works. Make a point of the fact that nobody needs to climb or risk a fall.

Fallback. If the children freeze, have the breeze give a small, hopeful puff that rocks the lantern, so they see it could be coaxed rather than grabbed. The moment they try a gentle idea, let the lantern drift down into their hands.

Nimbo the Cloud-Whale Calf (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. Up in the clouds the players find **Nimbo**, a young cloud-whale calf, with the gathered lantern light glowing softly inside it. Nimbo took the lanterns because it was lonely in the empty sky and loved their warmth, not to spoil the festival.

Play it softly. Let the children decide how to reach out: a kind word, an invitation to the festival, a promise to visit the clouds. There is no fight and no trick. When they offer friendship, Nimbo lets the light go, the lanterns rise all together, and Nimbo floats down to join the families, glowing brightest of all. End on that warmth. The children have won by being kind and full of ideas, which is the only way anyone wins on the Isles.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.